

HEP Adherence Cheat Sheet

PT COMMUNICATION LAB — FREE RESOURCE

"Fewer exercises, done consistently, beat many exercises done sporadically."

HEP Prescription Starting Point

VARIABLE	RECOMMENDATION
Number of exercises	2–4 (max)
Frequency	3–5 days/week
Sets	1–2
Reps	8–12

When to Progress

- Patient completes prescribed frequency for 2 weeks consistently
- Pain with exercise is less than 3/10 and settles quickly
- Patient reports exercises feel "too easy"

When to Regress

- Pain with exercise greater than 4/10 that persists after session
- Patient consistently misses sessions (plan is too hard)
- Poor form despite cueing

What to Say Instead of "Did you do your exercises?"

TRY THIS

"Let's focus on just two key movements this week. I want these to feel easy to fit into your day. Which two feel most doable for you?"

OR THIS

"What got in the way this week?"

RESEARCH REMINDER

Moelands et al. (2025): Higher prescribed frequency and dosage of home exercises significantly lowers patient adherence.

Martinsen et al. (2025): In-person supervised exercise had 4.2x higher odds of adherence compared to app-based exercise.

The One Question That Changes Everything

"On a scale of 1–10, how confident are you that you can do this at home?"

If less than 7, ask why. Solve that why.